‘You’ve changed.’

Those words, coming from him, always stung me like nothing else: they suggested I was cheating with my soccer and with my life by pretending to be someone or something I wasn’t. Dad knew how to get to me and so did Alex Ferguson. What he told my mum after that West Ham game was his way of saying the same thing Dad had said years ago. I knew how alike they were: stubborn, for a start. Maybe what neither of them really knew was how much I’d inherited that stubbornness as part of my own character. I couldn’t let myself buckle under, anyway. I was angry, at first, that Mum had been to see the boss but it made me realize that if I was this upset and this frustrated, I needed to face up to the situation instead of just letting it grind me down.

A few days later, the boss asked to see me. He wanted to talk about the arrangements for the England friendly against Australia: the understanding with Sven was that the senior players would only be involved for 45 minutes. Of course, as England captain, I needed to know what was going on. All that was fine. Now it was my turn. I’d thought long and hard since the West Ham game about what I wanted to say to the manager and what I wanted to hear from him. We’d had a couple of days off and that had given me time to get a few things straight in my own mind. I needed to know if he wanted me to leave United. And, if he didn’t but was going to carry on treating me the way he had been, I wanted him to know that I had one other option. I couldn’t imagine myself actually doing it but it was possible: I had enough in the bank to make sure that my decisions didn’t have to be about money. Rather than have my life broken apart by the game I loved, I had a choice: I could retire from soccer altogether. I got as far as discussing it with Victoria. I didn’t want to believe, though, that things might come to that:

‘Can we sort out our problem now, boss?’

‘What problem? Do we have a problem?’

‘Yes, we do. I’m not in the state I’m in for no reason. I’m depressed at the moment because of what you’re doing to me.’

‘I’ve not been doing anything to you,’ he said.

Then he went on: ‘You’ve been treating me the same way: ignoring me, not even looking at me in team talks.’

Which was true, but only because it had been all I could do, sometimes, to stop myself letting slip how down I was feeling. If you can’t deal with